

Sure enough, the finance ministry swung into action to calm the agitated market players who did not know what had hit them. Banks were asked to extend additional credit lines to brokers, and finance ministry officials assured the market of enough liquidity in the system. State-owned banks were told not to offload shares that had been deposited as collateral with them in a hurry, as this would further aggravate the downtrend in share prices. Some of the bank chiefs remarked on the strong fundamentals of the economy, some others promised full support to brokers through additional credit, and a few even spoke about increasing their capital market exposure as they felt valuations were attractive. Later, many brokers would complain that banks were offering them additional short-term credit, but at interest rates as high as 24 per cent.

The finance minister himself stepped in to say that all was well with the country.

The market opened for trading an hour later, and there was some semblance of sanity. Still, every rise was met with heavy selling, and the Nifty finally ended the day at 4,900, and the Sensex at 16,729. With a near 25 per cent dive from its peak over just seven sessions, the bull market appeared to be over.

Many small-timers and part-timers in the market had been wiped out for good. It would be years before they fully got over their trauma, and could even bring themselves to think about the stock market. Some of the larger firms and players too had just about managed to avert serious setbacks. For many, that dream house, dream car, or the month-long sightseeing tour of Europe would not be possible for some years to come.

As for me, I was a rich man. I had made the boldest bet of my career so far, and it had paid off handsomely. But it was not entirely about the money. My satisfaction lay in my decision to stand up against the market right in the midst of a raging bull run and coming out on top.

I thought of celebrating my triumph in style by taking Bina and the kids out for dinner at a five-star hotel that night, and gifting them a grand vacation in April to any location of their choice. For some reason, I decided against it. Maybe it had to do with a subconscious feeling of guilt, or not wanting to tempt fate. Instead, I chose to unwind at home over music and a long chat with Bina.

I was gripped by conflicting emotions. On the one hand, I wanted the world to know of my success, and yet, I was not comfortable at the thought